

Reflection (10/02)

In the last two weeks since my last written reflection, I have continued to research, read and annotate articles in gerontechnology and adapting technology to older adults, and to understand the barriers from seniors utilizing internet technology. One specific piece of terminology that has been influential in the last two weeks has been “codesign,” or “participatory design.” I have been reading more about the technology-senior network when it comes to solutions that were created with codesign in mind. This has been influential in my thinking, as I have gained some academic resources that illuminate this aspect of my capstone project, as “codesign” was important in the conceptualization of this project in my development of it earlier this year.

Additionally, I have been looking at the infrastructure surrounding technology around informal caregivers of older adults, and looking into the academic conclusions when it comes to the unique struggles of these informal caregivers, and attempting to see how these struggles are influenced, or could be influenced by technology. Informal caregivers are represented in a significant part of the US population, where some statistics say that one in four adults are in some way informally caring for an adult in their life over 50. These informal caregivers have expressed the need for technology that in some way gives peace of mind, through things like automated pill dispensers or health monitoring technology.

However, informal caregivers have also expressed that the lack of using these types of technology is because of product inconsistency, and the lack of multifaceted, or multiplatform solutions, and the struggles with actually utilizing the technology provided. I feel that this avenue of thought could be rewarding, as these caregivers have too little time in their day to deal with solving tech issues, where I believe that I could provide some kind of solution there.

Beyond research, this week I was able to meet with Valley Village, and being the process of setting up my I.T. help sessions there. The plan that I outlined with them was to start offering my time with one-on-one sessions where I would help residents that sign up, or express interest in Tech help. This would allow me to connect with Valley Village participants, and understand the common issues that come up in daily life. Moreover, this will provide me with time to conduct some interviews. Carrie Potter-Earle, the Activity and Volunteer Coordinator will be reaching out to let me know what she needs from me so that I can conduct these anonymous interviews that corroborate the HIPAA guidelines.

Secondarily, after gathering information from Valley Village residents and learning about their common tech struggles, I plan on holding some group, workshop-oriented, sessions that provide awareness or skills that tackle the issues that were most prevalent in my initial findings. This will provide me with some direction in my design process. Additionally, it will show what kinds of solutions are the most influential when it comes to helping older adults with their technology struggles. At the end of this capstone, I intend to include Valley Village in my final presentation for the year.

Something that I realized I need to ask about is conducting interviews with Valley Village staff, and their experience as caregivers trying to solve technology issues. By the week of the 19th, Carrie said that I would likely be able to start these sessions. This is later than I had expected, but I intend to relegate this by spending more time in their building, and providing sessions multiple days a week, assuming the demand exists (which in my experience there will be).

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